# Winter Sequences

## By Diane Wakoski

## INTRODUCTION

*God is the master of beauty in unexpected places. All of us expect a rose to be beautiful. But sometimes we look at people, who don't appear especially attractive or talented, and because we can't "see" any beauty, we assume it's not there. How shallow of us.*

*I believe every person and thing created by God is something beautiful; but unfortunately, half the time we make our judgment in one glance. We see the imperfections and not the possibilities. If we were to look hard enough, perhaps we would see the secret of unexpected beauty.*

*Winter Sequences by Diane Wakoski*

The rain was as slight as
the sound of someone's breathing at night. The day in
the mountains pale grey.
We had brought good cheeses,
a Boursin I especially liked,
wine, and a Pinot Chardonnay,
some liverwurst, french mustard,

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pears, apples

for a picnic.

But first we hiked a simple circuit trail
which led us through deep mulchy ground.
I found surprising fungi
and didn't have a field guide to identify them by. Tiny
orange balls
on needle stems.
Snowy white puffballs
looking as if some golfer had lost them,
even the old puffballs turning brown,
wearing prickly skins like sycamore fruit.
Step by step, as I walked along
picking out inky caps,
I kept my secret.
First I would ask myself,
could I tell it so that it captured the moment?
No.
Then thinking about it more and more

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I just wanted to spill it.
But I've remembered too much about what I've learned
to really spill it.

I hold my secrets.
They are poems only I can read. In the dark
under the stars.
No, once it is a secret
there is no joy in telling.

Rain cleared one muddy spot on the grass across from
my office.
I walked by it looking closely for mushrooms.
There were none.

Can I tell you now without
sounding like a fool?

The air is so cold it stretches across your face
paralyzing it,
making you think

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a hard glue has dried there
and left your face immobile.
The sun is shining as brilliantly on the pyracanthus
as a piano performance of Rubinstein.
The scene could either be a palm-tree-lined street
in Los Angeles
with pink stucco houses, mock orange, and jasmine
bushes or a New England town,
covered with fresh snow
where the crunch of boots shakes
holly wreaths on the porch door.
Does it matter where you find beauty?
that it immobilizes you,
makes you want to stop the passage of time,
makes you define each object
Landscape, the most brilliant
and terrible kind of beauty
causing us to remember our mobility essence of life
and wish we might stand still,
just stand still.

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White mushrooms,
as large as the headlights on a car, Pure white.
Flat as an operating table.

It is precision
that defines beauty.
Beauty
is either contrasts or subtleties,
the unexpected
or
the inevitable. This is a coda
for descriptive information:
not poetry.
White mushrooms.
Three of them, as large as the open lips of calla lilies.
Their brown perfectly ribbed gills
cool and fleshy,
touching, like the cool skin of someone you love

I kept thinking and holding my secret
to myself

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as we hiked that trail
knowing that if as we stopped either in the climax
forest
or the field on the other side of the mountain
filled with foggy milkweed pods,
and striped green gooseberries,
that if I said,
"A few days ago I saw three mushrooms as big as the
headlamps of cars/
They were on a lawn across from my office.
I bent down on my knees to see if they were real, and
touching them ,
found they were cooler and softer than skin. A dolphin's
skin perhaps.
I thought they were a trick.
I did not believe they were real.
Some new plastic, perhaps, invented for rich
suburbanites.
I questioned whether they were real.
I wondered, if they were real, had someone
planted them there

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to make a fool of me.
I asked myself whether I should pick them.
I pondered why, if they were real, no one
had already
picked them.
I bent down and touched them.
I was almost afraid of them.
I walked away and did not tell anyone.
I was afraid no one would understand
how beautiful they were,
no, how excited I was.
I still do not know if anyone can know. I still have not
revealed
my secret."
that if I said this,
anyone would understand.

When you remember
all the mushrooms or wild fungi
you have come upon by surprise
or

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other
sudden-nesses,
a blue crocus
early
anxiously out of the snow,
it is no more exciting
than seeing that red male cardinal
flashing his wings against the snow of winter. Common,
like arterial blood.
The question becomes
how do we live with the secret of unexpected beauty?

Three cardinal feathers fallen against the snow.
Jonathan's gleaming black dog, Pearl, running in the
crystal park.
My three mushrooms, like the beautiful white hands of
the embroiderer,
growing out of the earth.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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